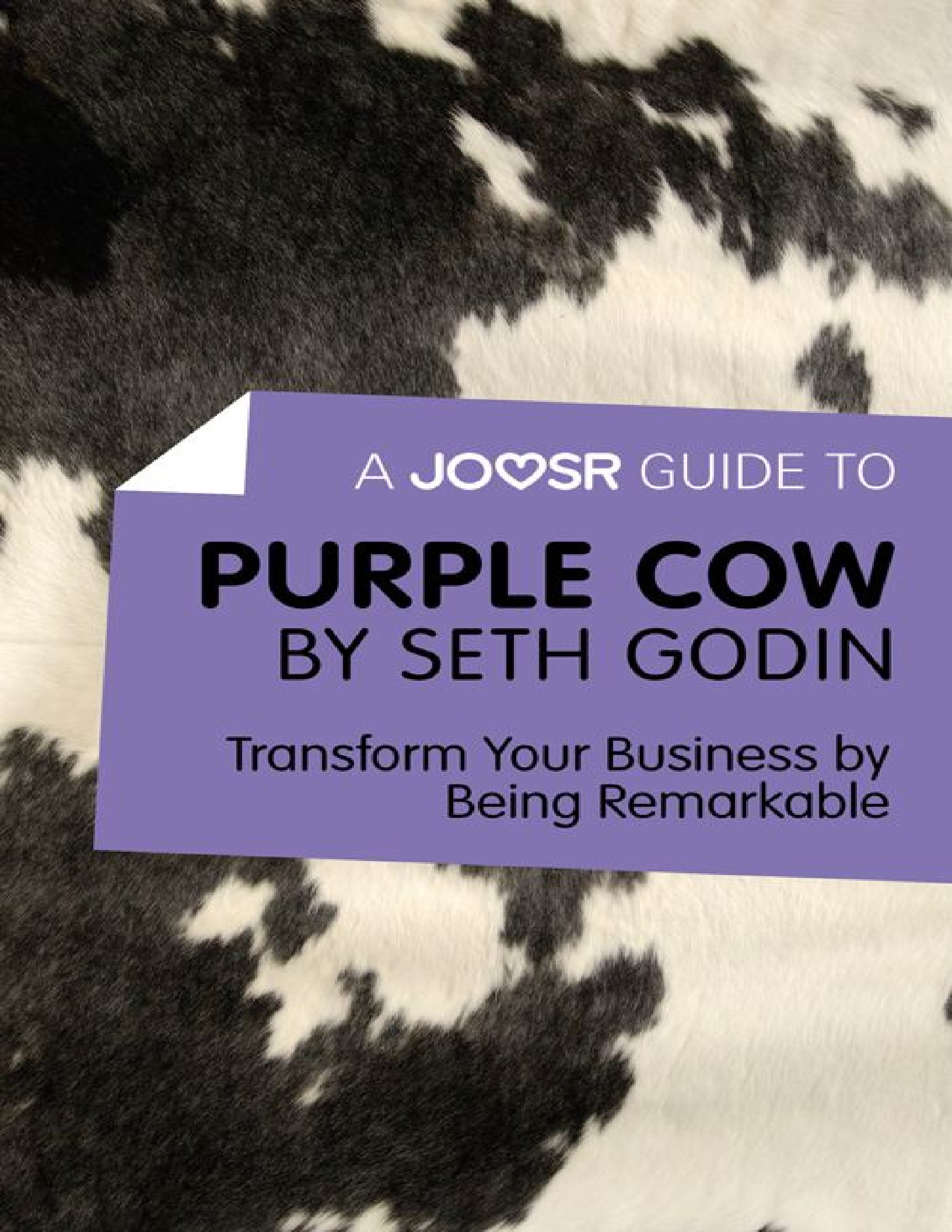




A JO♡SR GUIDE TO

PURPLE COW BY SETH GODIN

Transform Your Business by
Being Remarkable

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BY SETH GODIN

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What's it about?

For years, marketing was a science. It was simply a matter of having a good product, pricing it well, promoting it with advertisements in newspapers, on TV and in other media, and waiting for suitably enticed customers to materialize. Other factors such as packaging and ad placement were important, but as long as you had the basics down, your campaign was almost guaranteed success.

Unfortunately for marketers, this is no longer the case. Even the best of products are now lost in a sea of competing advertisements, consumed by an industry that copies its innovations, and ignored by an audience that simply doesn't have time to be advertised to. A good product with good marketing just isn't enough these days. To find its audience, a product must stand out—like a giant purple cow in a field of boring brown cows. To thrive, your product needs to be *remarkable*.

Purple Cow outlines the future of the marketing world, from the methods used to make a product, to the channels it travels to find its way into your customers' hands. Here, you'll learn how to make your product stand out just as a purple cow would, attracting the attention of new, loyal customers. You'll find out whom exactly to design your product for, how to overcome fear and take risks for true success, and how to continue on once your remarkable product becomes a hit. The face of marketing has changed forever, and with this book, you'll be able to adapt with it.

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The amount of current advertising has changed how people find products

Before learning new ways to advertise to customers, it is necessary to understand why your current methods are not working. This will help you learn exactly what you need to change in order to have success with future products. While your present advertising methods may be tried and true, they are just not as effective as they once were.

Centuries ago, before advertising became common practice, makers and companies would find success simply by being the best. In any market, the best available version of a product would be the one that triumphed, until someone made a newer and better one. This worked because the primary method of hearing about new products was word of mouth, so if yours was good enough, you could count on your customers to spread your reputation around.

This all changed dramatically when advertising came about. Advertising quickly became the most reliable and manageable way to ensure a market heard about new products, which meant that simply having a quality product was no longer enough. You can see the importance of this in action by looking at a recent case study in Facebook's short-lived "Facebook Poke" smartphone application. The app was designed as a competitor to the popular "Snapchat" app, with more features, better integration with social media, and easy-to-use messaging. But within two years, the app was removed from online stores, considered a failure. Why did Poke fail, despite having a better product? Simply because their advertising wasn't as effective as their competitor's.

The ability to advertise a product directly to consumers quickly became invaluable. Using television, newspapers, and other forms of media, you could get your product in front of customers more easily than ever before. So why isn't this working now? Ironically, the reason your current style of advertising isn't working well is *because* it's worked so well in the past. Thousands of companies now advertise millions of products using the same method, putting their ads on television, in movies, in newspapers, and even by roadsides. Because advertising is so prevalent in our society, it's become

unremarkable, which means consumers have stopped paying attention. They still want products to suit their needs, but confronted by a sea of advertisements, how can they find the product that's right for them?

Now, it's not enough to have a product that's simply good, nor is it enough to put that product in front of the customer with an ad. To get the attention of a modern-day audience, you'll need to find a way to stand out. You need to create a purple cow.

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Knowing how your market finds products is key

The first step to creating a “purple cow product” is to know your audience—but not in the way you might think. While demographic information is important, it’s also crucial to know how every subdivision of your market is reached, and how these individuals come to discover and accept new products.

Your market can be split into three major groups:

- **The innovators and the early adopters** are the people who like having a product first. Whether they need it or not, they enjoy getting an edge on everyone else by having the latest gadgets and goods. These are your dream customers because they will actively seek out advertisements and product news, looking for innovative things to purchase and get excited about.
- **The majority** of people in your market are set in their ways. They’re more difficult to market to because they’re happy with what they have and are not actively searching for a new product. These people tend to enjoy the stability and reliability that comes from what they already know, but are open to new ideas and products, provided they can be convinced they’re an improvement.
- **The adapters** will always be the last to pick up a new product. These are the people who buy something new not because they want it, but because they absolutely have to. For them, the only reason to switch to something new is because the old standard stopped working or is no longer supported. For example, a typical adapter would have loved cassette tapes, and would have only made the switch to compact discs once their favorite artists no longer sold their music in cassette form.

Current advertising trends involve marketing directly to the majority, but this is not effective anymore. Ads appeal to people who pay attention to them, and since the majority aren’t actively looking for new products, they will often disregard even the best of advertising. Word of mouth has now regained the power that advertising once took from it. This means you need to reach the enthusiastic, influential people in your market, who will then

spread the message to others. You'll learn exactly how to get this group's attention in the next section.

When you market your product, focus on the innovators and early adopters. If your product is remarkable, not only will this group be drawn to it, they'll be able to advocate its benefits to the majority.

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If your product is remarkable, your audience will come to you

We've established that the only people it's really worthwhile advertising to are those who are most likely to purchase your product first—the innovators and early adopters. So, how do you advertise to these people? The truth is, you don't!

With conventional advertising, you're trying to convince a marginally interested audience to look at and eventually try your product. But the early crowd isn't just marginally interested—they are, in fact, *more* interested in finding new products than anyone else. This means that you don't have to use advertising to draw them in, as they will come looking for you!

While the innovators and early adopters may already be looking, with an excess of different brands and products on the market, they're seeking something that stands out. Even if your product is better than every other product on the market, it still must stand out somehow to be selected by your target group. Your job is not to produce advertising that sells your product, but to produce a product that sells itself. You shouldn't start thinking about attracting your audience at the beginning of your marketing campaign, but from the moment you begin to design the product. If your product sparks the interest of innovators and early adopters, they will soon view it as remarkable and wish to purchase it. Now the market will come to find you, instead of the other way around.

To be remarkable, your product can't just be a small improvement on what's already out there. You need to create something that will be a huge leap forward, offering special value that your audience can't find anywhere else. Think about how Apple's iPad entered the tablet computer market. It combined the best of both laptop and phone: a quarter of the weight of a laptop, but with a large enough screen to work on and similar functionalities, plus remarkable ease of use thanks to its touch screen. This in addition to permanent internet connectivity gave the iPad a convenience level that set it leagues above the rest. The iPad was successful not because it was just good, but because it offered intuitive features found nowhere else at the time.

Creating a product like this will make yours stand out among other products—just like a purple cow would stand out from its brown herd. When your product is remarkable instead of just good, and the innovators and early adopters discover this, then the majority will begin to find you too.

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It's possible to make your purple cow more purple

Even if you've created a remarkable product, you should still take steps to guarantee that it stands out. Your goal is to be memorable, leaving an impression on the audience that makes them want to come back for more. Any creative, interesting actions your product or the advertising surrounding it can take to further that goal are a great positive.

Try these five methods to make your purple cow just a little more purple:

- **Be worthy of memory or parody.** Is your advertising over the top and funny? Perhaps it's intentionally awkward? Maybe it's simply so unique that people can't help but remember it. Either way, if people are imitating or recalling your advertising, it means it's in their minds—and so is your product. One great example of this is the 2006 “Shamwow” commercial campaign, which featured humorous and charismatic pitchman Vince Offer delivering memorable one-liners. Though the product already sold itself, the commercial made it absolutely unforgettable.
- **Develop a great slogan.** A slogan is a short, memorable phrase that reminds people what your product does. A good slogan sticks in people's minds and will likely be passed on from person to person. It greatly helps if the phrase is rhythmic like Walmart's “Save Money. Live Better,” catchy like Adidas's “Impossible is Nothing,” or has a musical jingle to go with it like McDonalds' “I'm lovin' it.”
- **Sell as much as possible to your existing fans.** Eventually you'll have dedicated customers who love your product and brand. These people have virtually given you permission to advertise directly to them. Take advantage of this with products, promotions, and campaigns that are exclusively for your most devoted fans. Not only will they continue to buy, they will tell their friends, which provides you with great word-of-mouth advertising.
- **Make your product collectible.** Whether it's to make a profit in the future or for nostalgic reasons, some people just love to collect things. These individuals may be willing to buy alternate versions of your product or special editions of existing products, and those who don't want to collect will be drawn to the variety.

- **Find hobbyists.** If you find your product attracts hobbyists, embrace them. Hobbyists are people with passion for a particular activity or interest, and this passion often drives them into the innovator market. Hobbyists may not be dedicated to your specific product, but if they have an interest in your field, they are likely to take notice of it. For example, someone who loves running will certainly take a look at your line of trainers because their love of the sport pushes them to.

Remember: These actions aren't what makes your product remarkable; they're simply ways to help your already-remarkable product catch the eye of your target audience.

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The risks of being unremarkable are greater than the risks of standing out

If the process of creating a purple cow product sounds risky, that's because it is. Many people are afraid of marketing to a niche. Since innovators and early adopters are only a small percentage of the market, some fear that people outside of that niche won't understand the product, which will generate criticism from people who don't see its point, or view it as slightly inaccessible. Such criticism is an inevitability: Since you are marketing toward a small group, it's almost guaranteed that you aren't going to be universally loved or even understood right away. This does not mean that your product has failed.

Remember that the most successful products often take heavy criticism when they launch. Apple's iPad received a lot of negativity upon reveal, but ended up being an enduring success. Wider acceptance comes through positive word-of-mouth, after the early adopters who have actually tried your product convince the indifferent or the critical of its worth.

So why risk it at all? The answer is simple: If you don't create something that stands out, you'll make something that's sure to be forgotten. To illustrate this, imagine a new restaurant that serves acceptable-tasting food. The fare is decent, so it stays open for a while, but a competitor that offers unusual, exciting food begins drawing customers away from them. The restaurant soon closes due to lack of customers because it couldn't offer them something unique. The death of your product or company is what you risk if you fail to stand out. To survive in the long term, you need to be remarkable.

If you're in control of your company, begin researching the innovators and early adopters in your market as soon as possible, and work on a new product that caters to them. Whenever you feel fear, remember the real risk that threatens your company. Ask yourself, "Will we succeed if we do nothing but blend in?"

If you're not in charge, you'll need to convince your boss to take a risk—a task often easier said than done. For bosses who fear risk, there's never a

good time to stand out. Convince your boss to take action by discussing with them the risks of being forgotten, as well as the possible rewards for being remarkable.

Creating a purple cow product may seem risky, but the guaranteed failure that comes with stagnation is where the real danger lies. Risk standing out and being remarkable for a better chance of longstanding success.

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Don't get lazy once you have a purple cow

You now understand the necessity of creating a remarkable product. You are aware of who you should be aiming this toward, how to make such a product, and why it is necessary to get past the fear of creating one. You even have a few ideas on how to market the remarkable. But what actually happens now that you've got one? What happens once you have a purple cow of your own, you've got the attention of innovators and early adopters, and your word-of-mouth exposure is attracting the majority?

To make sure your company continues to benefit from your purple cow's success, there are three things you need to do. First, you must focus on growing your company. You can do this by establishing your company's brand on your purple cow product. Use its success to expand your company and its offerings, creating more products to enhance customer enjoyment, and make the purple cow synonymous with everything you do.

You'll also need to do everything you can to keep your purple cow alive—this means milking it as much as you can! Focus your efforts on getting as much profit from your successful product as you possibly can through interesting marketing that makes the cow more purple, by offering sales and special deals, and by streamlining your production process. This will go a long way toward helping you achieve the first goal of creating a brand, giving you the funds you need to develop your company.

Finally, you need to start work on creating a new purple cow. If you're looking for long-term growth, this is the most important component in your plan. There will come a time in the future when your product will stop being remarkable, either because it's no longer needed or because your competitors have adopted some of your innovations. When this happens, you'll want to be able to start the process anew, creating another product that's a significant advancement. Remember that the next product you create can't just be a small improvement on the first. It must be remarkable in its own right—a bigger, better, “purpler” cow.

You may be tempted to simply reap the rewards your purple cow brings, enjoying the revenue while it lasts. However, plenty of big companies have

had a purple cow and profited from it, only to disappear because they didn't continue to grow. To sustain your success, you need to keep on innovating and surprising your audience; you need to continue to be remarkable.

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Final summary

Today's world is fast paced and busy, and consumers simply don't have the time to browse the excessive number of advertisements that fill the media. Ads online, in newspapers, on television, and in the real world now go largely unnoticed, and a superior product can be easily forgotten as the virtual noise of competing ads crowds it out. A good product that is marketed to the majority simply doesn't cut it anymore. To thrive in any market in the modern world, you need to be remarkable

Even then, a remarkable product itself is not enough. To truly grow, a company needs to aim their product at the most innovative and excitable people the market has to offer. It is these individuals who will drive your sales, making your product successful as it attracts the attention of the majority, who were previously disinterested. You can then find ways to make your product stand out even more. Through this remarkable product, your company will flourish, giving you the chance to establish your brand, expand your company as a whole, and design products that are even more remarkable than the first.

There is risk involved in being remarkable. You risk missing the mark, losing the interest of your target audience, and being left with an unprofitable product and a lot of criticism. But you take the biggest risk of all if you choose to blend in. Your products and company will get nowhere by being like the rest of the herd. Create a purple cow, and soon customers everywhere will come to see you.

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Now read the book

Purple Cow is a book for the modern world, both in its content and in its delivery. Author Seth Godin has divided his advice into many short sections, with each dedicated to a different point, example or concept. The sections do flow in an orderly fashion, but are also written to be mostly independent, making the book easy to dip in and out of. Together, these sections present a clear overall message that is as powerful, convincing, and challenging as it is convenient to discover.

Godin is the pioneer of “permission marketing,” a type of marketing focused on selling to consumers who seek a product out, rather than interrupting people to make a sale. The author’s highly original and transformative advertising techniques and methods have made him a powerhouse in the industry, and his specialist knowledge is clearly evident in *Purple Cow*. His methods can be applied to any industry, making this book a must have for every product design and marketing department worldwide.

With real-world examples in which Godin’s methods are proven, enjoyable anecdotes and clear steps for the reader to follow, *Purple Cow* reveals what every individual needs to do to create and market a remarkable product. If you’re looking to promote a product, read this book as soon as possible. Your methods might be outdated, but Godin will give you everything you need to succeed in today’s market—to become a purple cow.

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Key takeaways

- Don't be content with blending in. To be successful you must stand out, like a purple cow in a herd of brown cows.
- Focus your marketing on the people who seek out new products, not on people who are happy with what they already have.
- A small improvement isn't enough. To attract attention, you need to create a product with unique, remarkable value.
- Use your first remarkable product to expand your business, create new brands, and develop an even more remarkable product.

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